CHAPTER

4

TEAMWORK DELIVERS VALUE

By design and talent, we were a team of specialists, and like a team of specialists in any field, our performance depended both on individual excellence and how well we worked together. None of us had to strain to understand that we had to complement each other's specialties; it was simply a fact.

—Bill Russell

Professional basketball player

It's fortunate for business—and projects specifically—that people are naturally sociable. People readily form associations with others they like and with others with whom they find common affinity. These associations are the underpinnings for groups and teams that have become an important organizing principle for business. In both groups and teams, people find mutual comfort, security, and strength. For an everyday example, look at online social networking—and now, not only social networking but also online business networking. Social networking for business purposes has gone from the purview of early adopters to a tipping point for people and companies.

Of course, it has not always been this way. Until the mid-19th century, organizations in both the public and private sectors, save perhaps the military, were hardly more than cottage industries. But industrialization led by the railroads brought scope and scale that required something else. Frederick W. Taylor, a management scientist working in the United States in the pre–World War I era, more or less invented the idea of scientific management. His idea was that large-scale enterprises could be organized according to job descriptions and roles, with a hierarchy of managers in charge. People who had the requisite skills were thought of as interchangeable parts that could be plugged into jobs and roles. This idea—which came to be known as Taylorismi—fit well with factory industrialization, which was ramping up during the same period.

Taylorism was propelled to an unprecedented pinnacle by the compelling need for armies of workers to support the manufacturing and supply requirements of World War II.[1] However, within 20 years of the end of the war, the space program took a different approach: teamwork. What it brought was some amazing innovation. For example, as distinctly different from the Taylor theories of

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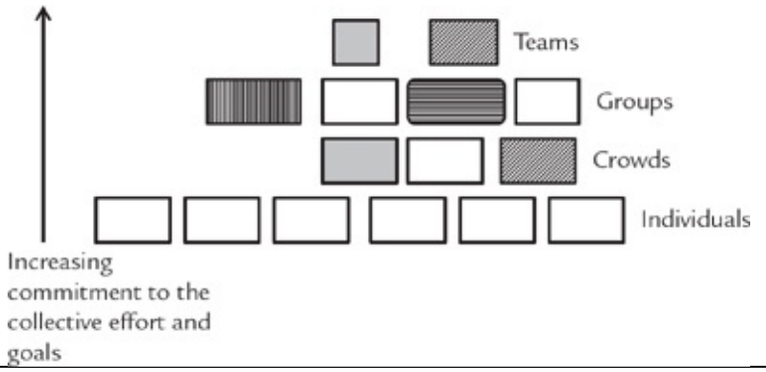
interchangeable “plug-and-play” assignments of people to roles, the space program teams recruited their members rather than accept manager assignments from a labor pool. Teams were multi-disciplined and internally redundant, meaning that it was intended that team members could fill in for each other and roles could be rotated to spread proficiency. Teams were persistent, meaning that the membership stayed together over long periods of time, developing a team culture and spirit and developing (or being characterized by) team-specific performance benchmarks. These various innovations—common to many sports teams—are largely missing from industrial Taylorism and were new to business in the 1960s. Clayton Christensen, a leading research academic specializing in how various forms of innovation propel business success, writes about teams and innovation:

“Innovative teams (and companies) perform best when discoverers honestly appreciate the pivotal role of those with strong execution skills (and vice versa) … so that the team or organization can view and solve problems from very wide angles.”[2]

FORMING GROUPS AND TEAMS

Family is the first group for most people. Like other groups, family groups promote intrapersonal communication, facilitate information exchange, organize and execute group activities, and reward behavior and achievement. But family is only the first group. Over time, most professional knowledge workers join many groups, and many of these groups evolve into teams. In this discussion, teams are at the top of the social order, as illustrated in Figure 4-1. That order includes individuals, crowds, groups, and teams. Commitment to a collective effort and goals increases from the lowest level, exhibited by individuals acting alone, all the way up to teams.

FIGURE 4-1 Social Order



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Teams are at the top of the social order.

Group dynamics

Forming a group for business purposes is a deliberate activity. Groups don't form unless there is both opportunity and motivation for the participants to interact. But not every gathering is a group, though some groups begin with crowds. Crowds are not groups, regardless of popular notions of "the wisdom of crowds"[3] and "crowd sourcing."[4] A crowd by itself has no common purpose or organized way to present ideas. Of course, in the Internet age, much of this is changing. Crowds now have effective ways to self-organize online. They can even organize or segment their messages with little effort, for example by using relevant hash tags on Twitter.

And now there are businesses that cater directly to crowd sourcing and crowd funding.[5] They even have an industry organization—crowdsourcing.org—to support them. For a fee, these companies will distribute a problem you submit to small groups or individuals who compete to devise the best solution, and also organize the competitors' responses. The winner usually gets a reward.[6] For new business and product ideas, crowd funding is a means to connect independent investors with entrepreneurs.

So, if a crowd is not a group, what is a group? A business group has these properties:

- A common purpose that attracts members either to join or stay.
- Division of responsibility and some distinguishing roles, such as team leader and functional contributor.
- Accepted norms for behavior and participation.
- Defined operating processes.
- Protocols for reward, discipline, or sanction. These protocols provide a means for attaching incentives to group membership and for dismissing undesirables.[7]

From group to team

Groups are not teams. Populations, partnerships, bureaucracies, associations, and committees also are not teams. However, forming a group is often the first step in forming a team. Here is a working definition for a team:

> A team is a social structure wherein all members individually and mutually collaborate toward the achievement of a common goal that is possible only by the committed and collective contribution of all members.[8]

Teams inherit the properties of groups. These properties are necessary for

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teamwork, but they are insufficient. Teams have these additional properties:

- A common goal that motivates all
- Individual and collective commitment to team success
- Collaboration and contribution of all members toward achieving the team's goal
- An inextricable link between team success and individual success
- Settled dominance.

Regarding this last point, each member of the team surrenders some of his or her personal power, independence, and dominance. In fact, for a team to work effectively, competition for dominance must be settled among team members. Those who have a greater command presence than others will tend to rise to leadership, whether they are formally appointed or not.

Project managers often must work with teams that are not really teams. For example, business executive teams are commonly formed to make policy, evaluate competing value propositions, and provide strategic order and guidance to portfolio and project managers. However, these executive teams are often less a team and more a group. Often there is unsettled dominance of both person and organization; the power and influence that come from formal authority and bureaucratic hierarchy are not easily set aside.

Values that inform teams

James Surowiecki, author of *The Wisdom of Crowds*, tells us that crowds can be pretty clever. Granted—but crowds and even groups lack certain values that are required for successful teamwork on projects. Here are the top seven team values:

1. **Trust:** A willingness to be vulnerable to, and accepting of, the performance and commitment of others as they act with you in your joint interest
2. **Commitment:** A pledge to apply all possible effort, energy, and ingenuity to the successful completion of the goal
3. **Accountability:** A willingness to be judged by others and to be accepting of personal responsibility for the completion of tasks assigned
4. **Continuity:** A belief that change should be subordinated to the completion of the team goal
5. **Simplicity:** An embrace of the virtue of absence of unnecessary complexity, though some very complex things may be as simple as they can be
6. **Clarity:** A willingness to promote order and transparency; in effect, the absence of confusion and obfuscation

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7. **Certainty:** A commitment to the absence of unmitigated risk and the presence of predictable outcomes.

Even teams that hold these values don't always perform as expected.[9] There are several factors that contribute to poor teamwork. First, there may be issues with the mission:

- The mission is not compelling; indifference to the mission doesn't inspire work.
- Mission boundaries are left fuzzy; confusion is a productivity killer.

Second, there are unresolved issues around team membership:

- Teams are made too large. Teams are a way to organize small numbers; they are not the antidote to hierarchy and organization on a large scale.
- Team members are assigned by resource managers to the team, not recruited to the team by the team leader.
- A "nemesis" member has not been included to neutralize groupthink.
- Membership is allowed to turn over too rapidly, thereby diluting cohesion and squandering productivity dependent upon personal relationships.
- Membership does not turn over often enough, thereby inhibiting new and imaginative patterns of ideas.
- Membership includes talented eccentrics who don't share and work collectively.
- There is too much competition among members, often leading to secrecy and compartmentalization, quite opposite to collaboration.

Third, there are administration issues:

- There are empowerment uncertainties, awkward and untimely decision chains, and confusion about roles, rights, and responsibilities.
- Many personnel issues are left unresolved: "What do I have to give up if I join the team?"

And fourth, physically distributed teams—also called *virtual* teams—have issues and trade-offs unto themselves that may not benefit a project situation. These issues and trade-offs are the subject of the next discussion in this chapter.

LOCATING AND STRUCTURING THE TEAM

Dilbert is a popular comic strip that parodies business situations, particularly the cubicle culture of modern business.[10] *Dilbert* was launched in 1989, about the time that the hard-wall office began to lose popularity. It was to be replaced by open-

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plan designs, more cubicles, and virtual offices for mobile workers. The telecommunications revolution that began in the 1990s increased the pressure on managers to allow virtual work. The flat-world paradigm described by Thomas Friedman[11] made virtual working inexpensive and practical for a wide array of organizations. And the drive for efficiency and productivity has reorganized business services in ways that make business boundaries more elastic. Some business functions are now done by others as a service, leaving the organization to focus on and do only its core competencies.

For most business and organizations, projects are not a core competency. Thus, projects are among those activities that could be done elsewhere by others on behalf of the organization—others like free lancers, partner teams, contracted outsourcing, and remotely located business units. But that said, the question remains for many: to co-locate or not?

Co-located teams

In 2012 business management columnist Lucy Kellaway forecast that there would be a migration back to the real office, where real people collaborate, innovate, and create.[12] In fact, we are told to expect the return of the landline; the jacket [for men]; the commute; the handshake; and above all the office itself. Out of fashion will be the virtual office. About this forecast we can say perhaps so, but it has also been forecast that business services will continue to grow as a major cross-national, cross-business global market, thus expanding virtual work.[13]

If the trend really is toward greater co-location, the disciples of agile methods will benefit. Agile methodology is built around person-to-person, face-to-face collaboration. It's pretty hard to do what Alistair Cockburn, a leading agile methodologist, calls "communication by osmosis"—that is, absorb what's going on around you—if you're not there to observe the body language and catch the casual comment. Cock-burn's ideas and observations are supported by numerous academic and industry studies, many of which are described by Thomas J. Allen in his well-regarded *Managing the Flow of Technology*. Related to this work, Allen is credited with invention of the so-called "Allen Curve" that shows a distinct relationship between the frequency of communication with colleagues and the distance separating them. The Allen Curve supports one theme of Allen's book, which is that innovation is strongly correlated with the number of independent colleagues within close reach—thus supporting the advantage of co-location.[14] But of course, not every project is "doing agile," so there are other drivers for the co-located team:

- **Defense:** People with jobs want to defend them by being seen, and being seen productively engaged.
- **Culture:** Leaders want to spread corporate culture and strengthen its influence.

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- **Inheritance:** Managers want younger workers to pick up the tricks of the trade from experienced hands, and managers want older workers to learn new techniques from the young.

It's not enough to just talk about co-locating a team in the same facility. The question remains whether or not a co-located open plan fosters innovation and project performance better than conventional offices and cubicles do. James B. Stryker has written about productivity in the open workplace, citing three keys:

1. **Visibility:** Sixty percent of those surveyed reported increased face time with team members if the workspace is on a main traffic route that gets lots of notice.
2. **Density:** More people, more communication—16 people in a 25-foot radius works well.
3. **Oasis:** There should be quiet space for meetings: 22 meeting spaces within 75 feet is a recommended figure.[15]

Virtual teams have difficulty with visibility and density, less so with providing an oasis, but virtual teams have their advantages, as discussed in the following section.

Virtual teams

Apart from not having the brick-and-mortar expense of co-located teams, virtual teams are advantaged by Thomas Friedman's famous formulation: the world is (technologically) flat.[16] For project purposes, all of Friedman's three convergences work positively for virtual teams:

1. **Convergence to a common platform** (which is in broad terms the Internet, but is also now the "cloud")
2. **Convergence to a capability for horizontal access to the platform** (meaning all connections to the platform are created equally, with democratic access for all)
3. **Convergence of lots of people accessing the platform** (so there are the advantages of the crowd and the propensity to share).

But these benefits are often offset by project management issues, such as the following:

- Virtual teams have no physical boundaries, but they have many virtual boundaries, every one of which is a potential management issue.
- There is a natural ambiguity about team member identity and territory; each virtual team member has a local identity, with its territory, and a remote identity, with its territory. Sometimes "local" and "remote" are in conflict, and

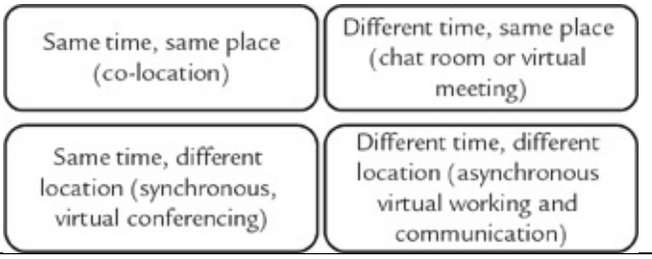
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that conflict must be resolved to reduce confusion and thereby improve productivity in the virtual remote location.

- Virtual teams have minimum density, thus potentially inhibiting innovation, a concept discussed elsewhere in this chapter.
- Virtual teams work asynchronously, having no common time of day or natural sequencing among activities. Consequently, many virtual team members may never meet each other online at the same time, and many may never talk on the phone with their teammates. Figure 4-2 shows a matrix of communication possibilities.
- Virtual teams are often teams of strangers, living and working at a great distance from one another. Strangers are less likely to inherit a work ethic from each other or from the project management office. Strangers are also less likely to trust each other.
- Derived, the team members may have difficulty developing a team culture, since culture is a consequence of shared values, shared experience, shared environment, and the shared influence of leadership.

FIGURE 4-2 Virtual Communication



Virtual teams communicate in many ways.

(Derived from B. Egeland, "The Complexity of Virtual Teams," *Project Management Tips* (June 30, 2010), http://pmtips.net/complexity-virtual-teams)

MANAGING THE VIRTUAL TEAM

The management objective of teamwork, as applied to projects, is to efficiently produce throughput, a value concept defined in Chapter 1. One useful metaphor for project management purposes is to treat each team member like a node on a network; each node has its own boundaries and natural protocols. In this network metaphor, the project manager imposes unique project protocols and means of

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access between nodes (team members). These protocols are intended to

- Maximize the innovation and creativity of the virtual team
- Promote efficiency and effectiveness
- Regulate workflow.

Innovation, creativity, and virtual density

Perhaps the most vexing factor for the project manager seeking to maximize value on a virtual team is the relationship of productivity, creativity, and density within such teams. Policies that encourage or allow low density may have the unintended consequence of squeezing off improved productivity. Studies that map productivity, creativity, innovation, and urban density suggest that higher density, better productivity, and more creative innovation are linked.[17] This gets back to the idea we started with: people are naturally sociable and generally eschew isolation. Thus, there may have to be a "productivity discount" for virtual teams, as compared to a baseline co-located team.

Virtual work cycles

Because virtual teams can operate around the clock, they need to synchronize configuration control of the project's intellectual property—documents, standards, designs, reports, data, and procedures. Synchronization errors can be a significant risk to the integrity of the material. Rules for configuration control typically require that check-in and check-out cycles operate 24 hours per day, so that no team member is locked out during his or her workday. Such a schedule puts constant stress on the system because there is no timeout for stabilization, for maintenance, and for processes that run in batch cycles to load and apply changes. One approach to relieving this stress is to rotate required downtimes among all workday cycles.

Within each work cycle, there are four attributes to be managed:

1. **Inheritance:** Virtual teams—unlike their co-located counterparts—do not routinely inherit the culture and values of the project organization. Some effort on the part of project managers is required to convey the values and culture to virtual team members who may only be transient members of the team or the business.
2. **Cohesion:** Cohesion is what binds a team together in times of stress. Cohesion depends greatly on trust. Trusting relationships do form in virtual teams, but they generally form more slowly, which is a risk to the near-term schedule and perhaps the associated budget.
3. **Coherence:** Coherence is what reinforces disparate elements. It's what drives teams to achieve more than their members can when working independently. In

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the absence of coherence there is often confusion, ambiguity, and wasted effort. Coherence is time phase–sensitive, meaning that it is sensitive to alignment on the calendar. Phase alignment brings coherence to teamwork, and it underscores the truth of such reinforcement maxims as "The sum is greater than the parts."

4. **Coupling:** Coupling is what allows one condition, trigger, or event to affect another. For example, activities are more highly coupled inside a team than they are coupled between teams. Face-to-face conversation is more tightly coupled than virtual communication, even if the conversation is a casual encounter, because face-to-face encounters couple body language very effectively. Reduced coupling is a risk to performance. For example, except for the tenor of the voice, body language may be all but missing in the virtual setting.

THE AUTEUR MODEL

In this chapter on teamwork, the auteur model may be out of place. The auteur—from the French, meaning *author*—is the one person identified most with a creative work. The most common application of the term is in the theater or film industry where the director is often the work's auteur. The creativity of the project often rests on this one person's shoulders.

But in the sense of one person's dominance over creative throughput, an auteur model is more or less the antithesis of teamwork. The auteur model as applied to innovation is an idea coined by innovation guru John Kao. Kao argues that often one individual can be so influential that the implementation team is subservient to him or her in executing all the details. Kao says that there is "a tight connection between the personality of the project leader and what is created."[18]

The auteur leader

In the project world, and especially the technology project world, the auteur model is a rare occurrence; a successful implementation of a project with an auteur leader, sustained over time, is even rarer. But take a look at the poster child for the auteur model: that was Apple in the years that Steve Jobs ran the company. Without its innovative leader in the 1990s, the company foundered. Later, when Jobs returned to Apple, the company again had its bold visionary—and it prospered.

Teamwork with an auteur leader

Jobs, of course, led a quite large, talented, and multifunctional team. He himself was the inspiration, but he relied on others for solutions. Jobs practiced a form of "adaptive team leadership" as defined by Ronald Heifetz.[19] Jobs' own prescription for teamwork, as the auteur leader, comprises the following elements[20]:

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- Lead from the top down. Value tenacity, patience, belief, and instinct.
- Choose team members who will themselves promote team success.
- Keep those staff members that are better than those who are simply very good.
- Exploit an understanding that innovation in technology involves a leap ahead.
- Trust that you can divine needs that quality guru Noriaki Kano might call “ah hah!” influencers in their product categories.
- Exploit technology trends.
- Drive design iteratively.

Leading teams for innovation

Greg Githens, a leading consultant for strategic initiatives, writes this about leading teams toward innovation:[21]

> Leaders commonly speak the word innovation. It conveys a sense of excitement and newness that motivates people…. Here are five things that leaders need to know about innovation:
>
> 1. Innovation is not the same thing as invention or as creativity. Innovation is best defined as ‘an idea, practice or object that is perceived as new by an individual or organization.’ … Innovators are people who search for outside of the familiar new ideas, and then bring the ideas into the existing culture. Thus, an important principle of innovation is: the future is already here[;] it is just distributed unevenly….
> 2. Innovations do not sell themselves…. Whether it is a new technological gadget, or a quality improvement program, there is no assurance that people will adopt an innovation. Leaders have an important role in developing the awareness of the innovation, positive attitude toward the innovation, and commitment to adopt the innovation.
> 3. Innovation involves choices and decisions. People evaluate an innovation with five filters, … [called the] TACOS criteria:
>
>   T—Trialability: Can I try it out before committing?
>
>   A—Advantage: Does it have greater relative advantage over what I am doing now or the alternatives?
>
>   C—Compatibility: Is this compatible with my values?
>
>   O—Observability: Can I physically see and experience it?
>
>   S—Simplicity: Is it simple enough that I can understand its features, function, and benefits?
> 4. It is … exaggeration to declare that people ‘resist change.’ … It is more accurate to say that people adopt innovations at different rates, with laggards the last to adopt the innovation….
> 5. Leaders help people cross the chasm [i.e., to new, different, and potentially challenging ways to do things].

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SUMMARY OF KEY POINTS

This chapter covers four key points:

1. Groups and teams are different from each other, as are individuals and crowds.
2. Team location matters greatly to how teams deliver value.
3. Managing virtual teams requires consideration for relationships and density.
4. The auteur model seems out of place for teamwork, but it need not be.

A team is a social structure in which all members individually and mutually collaborate toward the achievement of a common goal that is possible only through the committed and collective contribution of all members. Seven values inform teams: trust, commitment, accountability, continuity, simplicity, clarity, and certainty.

Virtual teams have no physical boundaries, but consequently they have many virtual boundaries and many more boundaries than a co-located team. Perhaps the most vexing factor for the virtual project manager are the relationships between productivity, creativity, and density with virtual teams.

The auteur model of team leadership depends on a team leader who has the capability to maintain artistic control of the deliverables and who relies on tenacity, patience, belief, and instinct. The auteur leader often leads his or her team to very innovative and creative solutions. An important principle of innovation is that "the future is already here."[22]

In the next chapter, our topic is judgment in the context of some uncertainty. We discuss several cognitive biases that affect decision-making and choices that affect value maximization.

NOTES

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2. J. Dyer, H. Gregersen, and C. Christensen, *The Innovator's DNA: Mastering the Five Skills of Disruptive Innovators* (Boston: Harvard Business School Press, 2011), 192.
3. J. Surowiecki, *The Wisdom of Crowds* (New York: Anchor Books/Random House, 2004), Chapter 1.
4. Crowd sourcing is a popular term for an "open call" to a disparate group to offer input to a question to be addressed by a group. Public comment on draft regulation is an example of crowd sourcing.
5. Crowd funding is funding of private ventures by "crowds" of independent investors.
6. Examples of this prize-driven competition are provided by competitions sponsored by the X-Prize

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Foundation in such areas as energy and environment, exploration, education, and life sciences. See www.xprize.org.

7. J. Goodpasture, *Project Management the Agile Way: Making It Work in the Enterprise* (Fort Lauderdale, FL: J. Ross Publishing, 2010), Chapter 8.
8. Ibid, Chapter 8.
9. H. Robbins and M. Finley, *The New Why Teams Don't Work: What Goes Wrong and How to Make It Right* (San Francisco: Berrett-Koehler, 2000). Some ideas in this chapter were inspired by D. Coutu, "Why Teams Don't Work" (Interview with Dr. J. Richard Hackman), *Harvard Business Review* (May 2009), http://hbr.org/2009/05/why-teams-dont-work/ar/1.
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15. J. Stryker, "In Open Workplaces, Traffic Headcount Matters," *Harvard Business Review* (Dec. 2009), http://hbr.org/2009/12/in-open-workplaces-traffic-and-head-count-matter/ar/1.
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19. R. Heifetz, *Leadership Without Easy Answers* (Boston: Harvard University Press, 1994). In the adaptive leadership model, the leader asks the team to find solutions different from those that are already established.
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21. G. Githens, "Five Things SI Leaders Need to Know About Innovation," Leading Strategic Initiatives blog (May 10, 2011), http://leadingstrategicinitiatives.wordpress.com/2011/05/10/five-things-si-leaders-need-

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to-know-about-innovation.

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